

Perfection and Its Problems

Suppose we allow that God is ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’. Can we unpack this concept to come to a coherent view of the divine? According to Anselm this definition entails that God must actually be *greater* than we can conceive. Doesn’t this mean that our attempt is doomed at the outset? In this chapter, after a quick sketch of how to begin the project of perfect being theology, I will discuss how it is possible for the limited creature to speak and think of the limitless creator, and then outline the list of attributes traditionally applied to ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’ with a quick explanation of why these attributes are seen as necessary to God. I shall conclude with a preview of the various problems that are raised against this picture of a perfect being in contemporary philosophy of religion.

How, then, to describe a perfect being? We can begin with two principles, which, according to the tradition, at least as developed by Aquinas, boil down to the same thing. First, as the source of all, God is *unlimited*. Any quality that would entail a limitation is to be denied of Him. Thus, for example, medieval and (most) contemporary philosophers of religion agree that God is incorporeal since being embodied is a limitation. The scope of the activity of those of us with bodies is confined to the capacities of those bodies. For example, even a body which encompassed the entire universe could not be *wholly* present everywhere at once. Any quality which is inherently limiting will be denied of God, and any perfection attributed to God will be attributed in an unlimited degree.

Interestingly, the earlier medievals seem to steer clear of using the term ‘infinite’ of God. Perhaps this is a holdover from the ancient association of

‘infinite’ with ‘incomplete’, ‘unfinished’ and hence imperfect. Anselm, writing at the end of the eleventh and beginning of the twelfth centuries uses variations on *infinitus* rarely, and does not describe the divine nature as ‘infinite’ in his philosophical works.¹ By the time of Aquinas in the mid-thirteenth century it is commonplace to speak of God as infinite in his very Being.² I shall use the term ‘infinite’ in connection with the traditional view of God, and I think it is safe to hold that, though the earlier philosophers do not use the term, this is not evidence of a fundamental shift with regard to basic beliefs about the divine nature. In *Proslogion* 20 Anselm says that God is ‘before and beyond everything’ and ‘by no means has an end’. Here he is talking mainly about God and time, but I think it is fair to say that he would agree that there is ‘no end’ to God’s wisdom, power, and so on.

A second principle, enunciated by Anselm in Chapter 5 of the *Proslogion*, is that ‘God is whatever it is better to be than not to be’. In the contemporary idiom, God must possess every ‘great-making’ property. The problem lies in deciding which properties are ‘great-making’. Both in the past, and today, the enumeration of great-making properties has proceeded largely on the basis of intuition. For example, you ‘just see’ that something possessing reason is superior to something which does not. True, the medieval philosophers in the tradition which we are drawing upon could have added that, since existence is good, the more there is to you, the better. The ability to reason adds a new dimension to the manner of one’s existing, and so rationality is a great-making property because the being with life *and* rationality has more to it than the being which is merely alive. (The notion of degrees of existence will be defended in Chapter 3.) I find this plausible and hope that our analysis of the nature of the perfect being will make this view more persuasive to the contemporary reader than it may seem at first glance, but I fear that we can never quite escape the need for intuition. This may just be the nature of things when it comes to values. If you do not see that it is better to be able to do things and to think than not, that a cat is better than a rock, and a human better than a pig, it may be difficult to convince you.³

Fortunately there is a core of agreement among the majority of philosophers of religion, medieval and contemporary. Everybody seems willing to allow that God is knowledgeable, powerful, good and a free agent. With respect to these attributes the questions that will arise will concern their scope and nature. But there are other attributes where the issue will be whether or not they should be considered ‘great-making’ properties at all. There are those who do not see any value to the traditional attributes of divine unity, eternity and immutability. Some, most notably process theologians like Charles Hartshorne, see multiplicity, temporality and

changeableness as virtues, inextricably bound up with the concept of a God who is really related to His creatures. How can such a conflict of intuitions be resolved? I shall argue for the tradition by presenting the motivation for seeing the debatable attributes as great-making properties and trying to show that, properly understood, they do not conflict with seeing God as the loving, personal being to whom we pray. I shall try to show that, while the critic of the classic tradition is right to insist that a distant and impersonal deity could not be all that our living God must be, he is wrong in failing to recognize that the classic tradition insists upon this point, as well. Throughout this discussion I will be, of necessity, working from a core of beliefs grounded in intuition, but there will still be plenty to argue about.

A perfect being, then, must have all the great-making properties and He must have them to an unlimited extent. Recently these core principles of perfect being theology have been challenged. Some contemporary philosophers of religion suggest that it is just impossible that God possess all the great-making properties in the highest possible degree. For example, there is the puzzle of whether or not God can make a being with a secret unknown even to Him. If not, He is not omnipotent. If so, He is not omniscient. We could solve the paradox by abandoning the tradition, choosing which trait is more important for a greatest possible being, knowledge or power, and just allow that God is limited with regard to the less important trait.⁴

Even setting aside the practical difficulty in deciding what degrees of which attributes are necessary to perfection, there are a number of serious problems with this approach. First, is this God adequate as the object of religious worship? Defenders of this position seem to allow, for example, that since a perfect being must be virtuous, and a virtuous being would not do bad things, God is less powerful than a being who can do both good and bad things. Surely from the religious point of view it is shocking to suggest that there could be a being more powerful than God.⁵

It could be insisted that we must accept a God who is so radically limited since this is the only way to resolve the various puzzles raised by the concept of a perfect being. I shall argue, however, that it is possible to resolve the paradoxes and leave God's infinite perfection and absolute sovereignty intact. This is important because the view that God possesses great-making properties, but to only a limited extent, entails consequences which are fundamentally at odds with the traditional understanding which insists that God is the perfectly unified and absolutely independent source of all. The tradition holds that creatures possess being and power and wisdom and justice and every other perfection because they receive them

from God. The perfections in creatures are a limited participation of the ultimate source. Though it is sometimes necessary for us to use the language of ‘having’ or ‘possessing’, God does not ‘possess’ these perfections. It is not that there is God and then, added on, various ‘perfect-making’ properties. As the absolute source and standard He just *is* all those perfections which flow forth to be reflected more or less in creatures. God is Being and Power and Wisdom and Justice, and so on. The first chapter of Anselm’s *Monologion* begins with the classic Platonic proof for God which moves from the existence of things possessing varying degrees of goodness to the existence of a source which must be maximally good, and succeeding chapters argue similarly for other perfections. In Chapter 5 of the *Proslogion*, after he has shown that ‘that than which a greater cannot be conceived’ must exist, he asks rhetorically, ‘Therefore what good could be lacking from this highest good, through which all goods exist?’ The Being which *is* Goodness and the source of all goodness could not ‘have’ goodness (note that in Anselm’s terms all perfections are ‘goods’) to a greater or lesser degree.

This understanding of God and His relationship to His ‘great-making’ properties and to His creation, which we will be unpacking throughout this book, is the standard medieval view of the Augustinian Neoplatonists and the more Aristotelian thinkers as well. Aquinas is adamant that God, as the first efficient cause, is pure actuality which equals absolute perfection, no lack in anything. All perfections pre-exist in God, since ‘nothing of the perfection of being can be wanting to Him Who is subsisting being itself’.⁶ He writes, quoting the Pseudo-Dionysius with approval, ‘God does not exist in a certain way; he possesses, and this before all others, all being within Himself absolutely and limitlessly’.⁷

The contemporary philosopher, of course, is free to reject the medieval approach, but one should not reject it without having at least considered it. And if one ends up deciding that Augustine and Anselm and Aquinas are fundamentally mistaken, then, in the interests of clarity, one should note that the God one has in mind is not the traditional God of the medieval philosophers. More importantly, *if* a coherent analysis of Anselm’s God, the one who just is all the ‘great-making’ properties to the highest degree, can be offered, then surely the proposed limited divinity will have to yield pride of place to it.

Throughout this book I will argue that it is the medieval approach, with its metaphysical views on the nature of the source of all, that best solves the various paradoxes raised by the notion of a perfect being. For example, on Anselm’s analysis it is immediately obvious that God, though omnipotent, cannot make someone who possesses a secret unknown to Him. Anselm’s

solution to the puzzle lies in an understanding of divine simplicity, so I will save consideration of it until the next chapter. Suffice it to say here that this divine ‘inability’ does not limit God’s omnipotence in the least.

‘That than which a greater cannot be conceived’ is limitless, and possesses all the great-making properties to the highest degree or infinitely. In the traditional view, God, as source, actually *is* the perfections in question, and is all of them in a perfectly unified way. But now we are confronted with a perennial problem in the philosophy of religion. God is a very different sort of being from those with which we are usually concerned. How do our words apply to God? The medievals devoted a great deal of thought to this question and suggested a variety of sophisticated answers which form the foundation of the discussion to the present day.⁸ To my knowledge the solutions they offered have not been superseded by any new and improved versions, so a quick canvas of the most viable of the medieval analyses of religious language should provide us with enough background to proceed.

Plotinus calls the source of all the One, and sees it as so transcendent that it is beyond all positive terms, even Being. In answer to the question of how we can speak of or describe such a thing, he responds, ‘We can’t.’ We can seek union with the One in a mystical vision beyond reason, but we cannot talk about it. The philosophers of the Book could not go this route. The Bible speaks of God and insists that we do so in our forms of worship. We must apply our language to God. The question is, what do our terms *mean*.

Maimonides, the great twelfth-century Jewish philosopher, agrees that we must use the words employed in our sacred writing, but we do not use them to describe God positively as He is in Himself. God is absolute unity and completely unrelated to His creation. Maimonides explains in Chapter 52 of Book I of his *Guide for the Perplexed* that the tradition legitimates the application of certain terms to God, but the meaning of these terms must be negative or causal. Thus when we say that, ‘God is good’, we may mean, negatively, that He is not bad. It is not that God is like the goodness that we know, only much more so. ‘Good’ simply means not bad. It does not tell us anything positive at all about what God is like. On Maimonides’ causal analysis, terms applied to God mean to indicate what He has caused. That is, to say that ‘God is good’ is to say that He is the cause of good things, but Maimonides insists that we cannot move from the effect to saying anything at all about the nature of the cause. Maimonides’ analysis of biblical language leaves us unable to talk about God as He is.

This seems a very difficult position for the believer who is commanded to love and worship the Lord. How can we love something if we have no idea at all of what it is? As Aquinas notes, these purely negative or causal

meanings are certainly not what we ordinarily intend when we speak of God. And if all attributes had a merely negative or causal meaning then any term would be as appropriate as any other. The term 'body' would be as apt as the term 'good' with respect to God since all we could mean by 'God is body' is 'He is not pure potentiality' or 'He is the cause of bodies'. Both of these statements are as correct as the purely negative or causal meanings of 'God is good', that is, 'God is not bad' and 'God is the cause of good things'.⁹

Fortunately for the future of perfect being theology, there do seem to be adequate ways of bridging the gulf between creature and creator and solving the problem of religious language. Here we can look only very briefly at three suggestions, rooted in the three different epistemologies of Anselm, Aquinas and Duns Scotus. (Scotus was a fourteenth-century philosopher who, though he sometimes used the thought of Aristotle, defended certain theses central to the Augustinian tradition, like extreme realism, the self-evidence of God and the possibility of univocal predication. We will see in Chapter 7 that he departs from both the Augustinians and the Aristotelians in his acceptance of voluntarism.) Anselm argues that we can speak of God univocally, that is, the words we use of God have the same meaning as when we use them of creatures. True, God and creatures are very different, but if a term is properly applicable to both then its significance must be sufficiently general to span the gap. An elephant is very different from a gnat, but the term 'animal' is applied univocally to both.¹⁰ And this position follows directly from his metaphysics and epistemology. Anselm's thought falls squarely in the tradition of Augustinian Neoplatonism in which the basic relationship of creation to Creator is one of participation, and the most fundamental epistemic fact is divine illumination.

Participation means that every good quality which is possessed by a creature is possessed through some sort of 'reflecting' or 'sharing in' the nature of the divine. The relationship is closer than that of copies to the original blueprint or mirror images to the object reflected but stops short, *well* short, of identity. The divine transcends its created image even as it pervades it. If this all sounds too vague and metaphorical, the Platonist can respond that it is just very difficult to describe a causal relationship which is *sui generis* and in which the cause is God. For the purposes of the analysis of religious language, the important feature is that it is in fact the same perfection which creatures reflect and which God just *is*.

Although the perfections in question are not sensible qualities, they have no color or smell, and so on, we can recognize them in creatures because we have received knowledge directly from the source of all through divine

illumination. We recognize wisdom and justice and goodness in things because we already have the idea of them in our minds, 'implanted' by God. Because of this inner knowledge we can appreciate goodness *per se* and hence apply the term 'good' to the creature in which it exists as limited and reflected and to the Creator in which it exists as identical with His nature. Anselm is adamant that the terms we use of the perfections in God and creatures are sufficiently general to cover both the unlimited cause and the created effects.¹¹

Aquinas has a more difficult task when it comes to defending the view that we can speak positively, not just causally or negatively, of God's nature, 'substantially' in Thomas's terms. He insists that, barring a miracle, all our knowledge, beliefs, concepts and so on begin with experience. We have no immediate experience of God. Our understanding of the terms we use for God is drawn from our observation of creatures. But if God is infinite and perfectly unified, how could our concept of an attribute, derived from the limited creature, be properly applied to God? It cannot be applied univocally, Aquinas holds, but nonetheless we can speak properly and substantially of God so long as we recognize that our language applies analogically.

In analyzing the signification of an attributive term there are two things to be considered. There is the *res significata*, the very attribute signified, and there is the *modus significandi*, the way in which the term can be applied to the particular kind of thing in question. According to Aquinas when we use a term of very different kinds of things, the *modus significandi* changes, and so the meaning cannot be exactly the same. Thus when we say, 'The dog is good' and 'God is good' the *res significata* of the term 'good' is the same, it is goodness. We are justified in ascribing the same attribute to God and the creature because of the causal relationship between the two.¹² However, because God is infinite and unified the *modus significandi* of a term applied to God and creatures is different. We cannot possibly comprehend just *how* God is good, and so although we do have an understanding of goodness, there is inevitably a vagueness and inadequacy when we use the term of the perfect being. Contemporary philosophers of religion can exploit this insistence upon the inadequacy of our concepts when applied to God to explain why it may be impossible to express certain difficult positions with perfect clarity. Care must be taken, though, to retain the notion that there is some sameness of significance when we apply our empirically grounded terms to God. Just how Thomas himself balanced the sameness and the difference, and how they ought to be balanced, are the subject of debate among contemporary students of Aquinas.¹³

Scotus, writing in the fourteenth century, offers an interesting reconciliation between Anselm's doctrine of univocity and Aquinas' epistemology. Scotus agrees with the Aristotelians that we learn through abstraction from sense data. The question is, what exactly is the content of our abstracted concept? Aquinas held that our understanding of the meaning of the term 'good' must inevitably involve goodness as it exists in creatures. Hence we can speak of God only analogically. Scotus disagrees. He argues that in order for us to speak properly of God, there must be some underlying sameness, genuinely applicable to the creature and God, which we are capable of grasping. For example, God is not good as a dog is good. If we cannot move beyond understanding 'good' except insofar as it applies to the dog and other good creatures, then we cannot properly use the term of God. Fortunately, though our concepts are produced by abstraction from sense data, we are capable of abstracting concepts of sufficient generality that they can apply univocally to God and creatures. We get our concept of wisdom, for example, from observing creatures. In creatures wisdom is limited. Wisdom *per se*, however, is neither limited nor unlimited. Wisdom is just wisdom. When we abstract the concept we can strip it, *in intellectu*, of all the imperfections which accompany wisdom in the creature but which are not part of the definition of 'wisdom'. Thus we come to a concept of perfect and unlimited wisdom, the wisdom of God. This is not to say that the limited knower can fully comprehend what it is to be perfectly wise. We cannot imagine or somehow 'picture' perfect wisdom, what it is like to be perfectly wise, but we can grasp the concept 'perfect wisdom' enough to apply it properly to God.¹⁴ To borrow an analogous example from Anselm, though by definition we cannot comprehend an ineffable being, we nonetheless understand the term 'ineffable'.¹⁵ Among contemporary philosophers of religion William Alston argues for this Scotist approach.¹⁶ The practice of religion demands that we be able to speak and think about God, and there are systematic philosophical analyses which suggest ways in which this can be done. Anselm and Scotus are perhaps a bit more optimistic than Aquinas, but even the analogical approach insists that we can speak literally and positively about God. From this point on I shall take it that when we apply attributes to God we are speaking of God Himself and we know (albeit in a limited or perhaps analogical way) what we are talking about.

RESUME
HERE

It will be useful now to sketch the great-making properties which 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived' must possess. (I do not claim that this list is exhaustive.) There is an important reason for this. We limited and temporal creatures must examine these attributes piecemeal. In God they are one and identical to His nature. If one tries to analyze one

attribute in isolation from the rest one inevitably fails to comprehend it properly. Too often contemporary analytic philosophy of religion works to solve this or that puzzle concerning some attribute of God but fails to take into account the relationship (that is, identity) of the attributes to one another and to God. I hope to minimize the problem by offering an outline of the key great-making properties which the reader can keep in mind as we work through the individual properties in detail in the rest of this book. This should enable us to approach perfect being theology more as a systematic whole, than as a series of isolated problems. I will conclude the chapter by noting a number of problems that will be raised against this Anselmian conception of God.

A great-making property which the classic tradition viewed as perhaps the most important, certainly non-negotiable, and which many contemporary analytic philosophers of religion seem content to jettison is simplicity. (The more detailed analysis of divine simplicity will entail that terms like 'property', 'attribute' and their synonyms are not accurate without serious qualification. Let them stand for now, in the interests of expediency.) God is perfect unity. This is the attribute to which Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae*, moves immediately upon having proved the existence of God. And, contrary to Peter Geach's interpretation, when Aquinas says that God is 'one' he certainly does not mean just that there are not several Gods.¹⁷ In that case one might as well say that Peter Geach possesses simplicity just as God does, since there are not many Peter Geaches. What Aquinas means is that there is absolutely no multiplicity or composition in God. All the qualities which we attribute to God are identical to one another and to God Himself.

Why say this? Anselm's argument is simple. It is a weakness to be corruptible. Anything that can be taken apart is corruptible. Anything made of parts can be taken apart, if not in reality at least *in intellectu*. So if God were thought to be composite, we could think of His destruction. But then we could think of something greater, an absolutely indestructible being. QED.¹⁸ Aquinas goes down the list of the various ways in which something could be composite, and shows that each of them involves the composite being in some sort of limitation or dependence on something else. So the perfect being must transcend all multiplicity, even that of a duality between essence and existence. God just *is* His very act of existing.¹⁹ I will defend this difficult doctrine in the next chapter. Once the doctrine of divine simplicity can be appreciated and embraced, many of the apparent paradoxes raised against the Anselmian conception of God can be resolved.

God's essence (nature) is to exist, which is to say that He is a necessary

being. If He exists then He *must* exist. Whether or not this entails that His non-existence is unthinkable, as Anselm argues, has been the subject of debate for the past 900 years. Another way of arguing for divine necessity is from God's absolute independence. In the classic tradition individual things are either necessary or contingent (with various possible qualifications in either case), and to be contingent is to be caused and dependent, since for anything that might or might not exist, an explanation is required for its being there at all. Whether or not contingent things require causal explanations is one of those perennial debates in modern philosophy, but contemporary philosophers of religion seem to accept the judgement of their predecessors that God must be uncaused and that it is greater to exist necessarily (one current way to put it is, 'God must exist in all possible worlds') than contingently.

Contemporary philosophers have been less willing to accept the tradition's insistence that God be immutable. According to Augustine and Anselm and Aquinas God does not change. This does not mean just that God's basic nature remains the same while His knowledge and activities can differ over time. Anselm's God is perfectly simple. His knowledge and activities are one with His nature. For God to come to know something or to do this and then that would be for Him to change in His very being. And that is quite impossible. God is the absolute best. He 'possesses' all the great-making properties to the highest degree. If He were to change He could only become a lesser being. In this traditional view of perfection there is no room for lateral motion. But if He *could* become a lesser being, He is corruptible. And if He is corruptible He is not 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived'. The God of the classic tradition does not and 'could not' change.

Not only is God immutable, He is also impassive. He does not suffer pain or sorrow. Augustine and Aquinas even seem to hold that God is not at all affected by human activities. Augustine argues from God's omnipotence that nothing happens in the world which is not entirely under God's control. Aquinas defends divine impassivity by pointing out that if God, as the best, is pure actuality, there can be no unrealized potential in Him. For us to act upon God would be for us to produce in Him some motion from potential to actual, which is absurd. Obviously there are difficulties here for the believer in a loving God. It may be possible, within Thomas's metaphysics, to reconcile God as a pure act of being with the loving Father who answers prayers. In any case the tradition does offer another approach in the work of Anselm who insists not only that God does but also that there is a sense in which He *must* respond to the actions of His creatures.

Another divine attribute which most of the medievals accepted and which many contemporary philosophers reject is eternity. It is not enough to say that God is everlasting, that is that He has always existed in the past and will always exist in the future. God is eternal. He is outside of time. All of time is immediately present to God but He is not temporal. There are a number of reasons for saying this. For one thing, to be temporal is to change. A genuinely immutable being does not change even with respect to temporal location. God is unlimited. To be temporal is to exist only in this present instant, this extensionless point where the yet-to-exist future becomes the gone-forever past. The only bit of our lives to which we temporal beings have access or which we have power over is this almost non-existent present slice. God, in contrast, possesses all of Himself at once and has access to and power over everything, everywhere, always. As absolute source of all, God must transcend the limitations of His creation. The medieval philosophers and the contemporary physicists tell us that time and space are categories of the physical universe, ways of describing the relationships between physical beings. God, as creator, cannot be bound by the categories He has made. (That God is non-physical has not been questioned by the orthodox, medieval or modern, and so we will spend almost no time in defending what no one disputes.) Seeing God as eternal solves a number of apparent paradoxes. How could an immutable being also be a creator? By doing all He does immutably in His eternal 'now'. How could God know future free choices? By 'seeing' them from His eternal 'present' as they are being made.

The attributes of omnipotence, omniscience and omnibenevolence have been less controversial than the ones listed above. Almost everyone agrees that it is best for God to be as knowledgeable as possible and as powerful as possible. And no one doubts that 'that than which a greater cannot be conceived' must be *very* good in some sense of 'good' related to moral goodness. This last attribute raises the very difficult problem of why a good God permits evil, but no one doubts that goodness must be among the qualities of God. The problems with the knowledge, power and goodness of God arise as a result of the paradoxes generated when we try to analyze just what they entail and especially when we ascribe them all to the same being. Finally, everyone engaged in the project of perfect being theology agrees that God is the Creator of our world. Almost everyone holds that He is a person who creates through a free act of will. Again the questions revolve around just what this entails, and how to view God's creative activity in the light of all the other attributes ascribed to Him.

The objections raised against this conception of God are legion. Here let me offer a quick preview of the sort of problems to expect. It is common

nowadays to hold that some of the great-making properties are inherently incoherent. Swinburne, for example, dismisses the idea that God is eternal, saying that he ‘cannot make much sense of this suggestion’. (And he is content with the corollary ‘refinement’ of God’s omniscience which involves denying divine foreknowledge, since a temporal God can’t know future free choices.)²⁰ The doctrine of divine simplicity has been widely repudiated since it is taken to mean that, if God just *is* His goodness, knowledge and so on then He is a property. And it makes no sense to hold that a person is a property.

A second sort of criticism involves the view that attributes ascribed to God are mutually inconsistent. Here are a few examples. A simple being cannot know and do many things, as required by omniscience, omnipotence and creativity. An eternal being cannot know what time it is now, and hence cannot be omniscient. A necessarily good being could not do evil, and hence could not be omnipotent. No being could be both omniscient and omnipotent since an omnipotent being could make a creature who had a secret unknown to anyone but itself, while an omniscient being must know every secret. We can defend God’s goodness only by holding that He could not prevent the evil choices of His free creatures, but if our choices are outside of God’s control then He is not omnipotent. If God is morally good, then He must choose freely, but if He is necessarily the best then He cannot do other than the best, so God is not morally good. And what sense does it make to speak of ‘choice’ at all, in the case of an eternal and immutable being?

A third difficulty was noted at the end of the last chapter. Even supposing we can make sense of the great-making properties and show them to be mutually consistent, won’t the concept of God at which we arrive be so distant from religious experience as to be . . . useless? What relevance could this eternal, immutable, impassive being have to us? This transcendent stranger can hardly be supposed to listen to our prayers. For us, what difference does it make whether or not such a being exists? This is a criticism that is often raised against the Anselmian approach, and I shall attempt to answer it throughout this work. Here suffice it to say that God’s love, to be treated under the headings of ‘Goodness’ and ‘Creation’, is as necessary a property as any other. God cares about you and me, He listens to our prayers . . . and He does it impassively, immutably and eternally.

NOTES

1. See Gillian Evans (ed.), *A Concordance to the Works of St. Anselm*.
2. For a discussion of this change in attitude towards *infinitus* see Leo Sweeney, *Divine Infinity in Greek and Medieval Thought*, pp. 319–36.
3. I do make some attempt in ‘The medieval approach to aardvarks, escalators and God’.

4. This is the approach taken by George Schlesinger in *New Perspectives on Old-Time Religion*. He presents the 'unknown secret' example in 'Divine Perfection'.
5. See, for example, Melissa Franklin, 'The indispensability of the single-divine-attribute doctrine', p. 434.
6. ST I, Q.IV, art.2.
7. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentiles* (henceforth SCG) Book I, Chapter 28, 9 (I am following the translation of Anton C. Pegis, University of Notre Dame edition).
8. Much of the modern discussion is carried on among Thomists (followers of Thomas Aquinas) and those conversant with the Thomistic approach like James Ross, *Portraying Analogy*. Among other contemporary philosophers of religion, it is probably William Alston who offers the most sustained discussion of religious language. In his *Divine Nature and Human Language* he argues for speaking about God literally, as opposed to metaphorically (pp. 17–63) and suggests how to go about doing so (pp. 64–102).
9. ST I, Q.XIII, art.2.
10. Anselm makes this case in discussing 'freedom' in *On the Freedom of the Will* 1 and 'justice' in *On Truth* 12.
11. See Chapter 5 of my *Neoplatonic Metaphysics and Epistemology of Anselm of Canterbury*.
12. See John Wippel, 'Thomas Aquinas and participation'.
13. See W. Norris Clarke, 'Analogy and the meaningfulness of language about God'; Ralph McInerny, *Studies in Analogy*; James Ross, 'Analogy as a rule of meaning for religious language'; John F. Wippel, 'Thomas Aquinas on what philosophers can know about God'.
14. Duns Scotus, *Oxford Commentary on the Four Books of the Sentences*, Book I, Distinction III, Questions 1 and 2.
15. Anselm, *Response to Gaunilo* IX.
16. William Alston, 'Aquinas on theological predication', p. 175.
17. Peter Geach, 'The meaning of 'God' – II', p. 87.
18. Anselm, *Proslogion* 18.
19. ST I, Q.3, art.7.
20. Richard Swinburne, *Is There a God?*, pp. 8–9.